

Data and Metadata Profile

The Data

For my term project, I am using a Kaggle-hosted collection of datasets that contains anonymized U.S. government immigration enforcement records (covering arrests, detainers, detention stays, and detention stints) from September 2023 to mid-October 2025. These records originated from the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), a Department of Homeland Security agency, and were acquired through Freedom of Information Act requests made by the Deportation Data Project (DDP) organization. The collection also provides “lightly processed” versions of the raw files to simplify analysis and as for usage restrictions, only “CC0: Public Domain” is listed on the Kaggle webpage.

In total, the collection consists of 12 files in .xlsx, .csv, and .parquet formats. Specifically, there are 4 files in .xlsx format (one for each data table ('arrests,' 'detainers,' 'detention-stays,' and 'detention_stints')), 4 files in .csv format (one for each of the aforementioned data tables), and 4 files in .parquet format (one for each data table). Files in the .xlsx and .csv formats can be opened using popular spreadsheet programs such as microsoft excel or google sheets and the .parquet files can be viewed by downloading a dedicated parquet viewer (for example ParquetViewer), using an online viewer (if wanting to avoid downloading software) (like [ParquetReader.com](https://parquetreader.com/)), or by using programming applications (such as Python or R).

Key stakeholders for this type of data are numerous and quite wide ranging; the data creators (ICE), data publishers (members of the DDP), policymakers, news outlets (or individual journalists), immigration attorneys, researchers, non-government

organizations focused on immigration or human rights, activists, and members of the general public (especially because of recent events) could all have a vested interest in this dataset.

The Metadata

Though not structured according to any metadata standard, the metadata I found through the Kaggle webpage, the individual data files, and within the 'Data Dictionary' (found under the 'About Dataset' section on Kaggle), was overall pretty informative. Specific metadata found on the Kaggle webpage were the 'Activity Overview' (shows the number of views and downloads of the data collection), the 'Metadata' section (lists the collaborators, authors, coverage, and provenance of the datasets), the 'Tags' associated with the data collection (found on the right-hand side), and how large the collection is (in GB, found under 'Data Explorer' on the right-hand side). The data files themselves and the 'Data Dictionary' contained metadata that were primarily structural in nature. To illustrate, column headers and the number of columns were indicated for the data files, while the 'Data Dictionary' had information like the descriptions of the overall data tables, variables included within them, and the type of input (date, text, numeric, or binary) that could be observed inside of each cell of the data tables.

Altogether, I thought that the metadata was mostly sufficient for user discoverability purposes. However, an area that I do think can be improved upon is with the 'Tags' (keywords associated with the data). Notably, terms like 'immigration,' 'undocumented persons/immigrants,' 'illegal aliens' (though this descriptor is controversial), and 'deportation' are not included but especially relevant with this

dataset. For users that are planning to use any one of the datasets within the collection, a significant improvement could be made to where helpful information is located. For instance, while a guide is linked to (under 'Guide in Navigating the Data'), it would be more user-friendly to include the numeric codes and their explanations (such as the meaning of "287(g)") directly on the main webpage with the data tables or on the separate webpage for the 'Data Dictionary.' I had to search extensively before finding an explanation for "287(g)," which was embedded in a paragraph midway through the 'Guide in Navigating the Data,' which is on a completely separate webpage.

Related Publications

Several publications have been associated with the datasets and were listed within the DDP's 'Guide in Navigating the Data': *A National Study of Immigration Detention in the United States* by Emily Ryo and Ian Peacock, *Manipulating Risk: Immigration Detention Through Automation* by Kate Evans and Robert Koulish, New York Times article *More Deportations Follow Minor Crimes Records Shows* by Ginger Thompson and Sarah Cohen, and Bloomberg article *Thousands of Detainees Have Been Jammed Into Jails Biden Vowed to Close* by Monte Reel and Sinduja Rangarajan. The DDP's Guide also included publications written by the Co-Director of the organization, David Hausman: *Risk Assessment as Policy in Immigration Detention Decisions*, *The Unexamined Law of Deportation*, and *Sanctuary Policies Reduce Deportations Without Increasing Crime*.

In doing my own general web search using Google and including keywords 'deportation data project,' 'trends,' and 'article,' I was able to locate quite a few recently

published articles from the Prison Policy Initiative, NBC, The Colorado Sun, and the Utah News Dispatch: *New ICE Arrest Data Show the Power of State and Local Governments to Curtail Mass Deportations* by Jacob Kang-Brown and Brian Nam-Sonenstein, *Deportations, ICE Street Arrests are Way up—and so are Arrests of Immigrants With No Criminal Convictions* by Suzanne Gamboa, *ICE Arrested More Than 3,500 People in Colorado in 2025—including Babies and the Elderly* by Taylor Dolven And Sandra Fish, and *What We Know About How ICE Arrests Have Increased in Utah Under Trump* by Katie Mckellar.

Repository Profile

The Repository

I have chosen to deposit the “ICE Arrests, Detentions, and Deportations” dataset, which contains U.S. government immigration enforcement records covering arrests, detainers, detention stays, and detention stints from September 2023 to October 2025, with the Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research (ICPSR). I found this repository to be a strong fit because the ICE dataset falls squarely within ICPSR’s collection scope, which explicitly includes administrative data, as outlined in its Collection Development Policy. In addition, ICPSR already hosts several related administrative datasets focused on immigration and enforcement, making it an ideal context for maximizing the discoverability and long-term accessibility of the dataset.

To evaluate the accessibility of ICPSR’s hosted datasets, I conducted a brief test download. After verifying my institutional email, selecting my department (Library and Information Science), and designating my role as a graduate student, I was able to successfully access a dataset. Although the only access mechanism I observed was through the direct file download, the overall process of obtaining a dataset was overall uncomplicated and easy to navigate.

What is Accepted

Anyone can deposit data with the ICPSR. While ICPSR maintains a defined collection scope, any dataset that meets the terms of its Collection Development Policy may be deposited and made publicly available through openICPSR, its open-access repository. According to this policy, the ICPSR excludes data that cannot contribute to

the scientific investigation of the social and behavioral dimensions of human life, data that must be purchased, data with restrictive access conditions (except those protecting human subjects), data already available through another repository, copyrighted data, or data dependent on unavailable software.

As for what the repository will accept, the ICPSR's holdings span numerous disciplines and data types, with the primary expectation that datasets have "demonstrated importance" to the social science community (meaning that they are unique, substantively valuable, and possess enduring research or instructional value).

To ensure accessibility, the ICPSR prefers data formats that are easily accessible, or in other words, can be easily used with common statistical or analytical software, notably R, SAS, SPSS, or Stata, though delimited or ASCII files are accepted as long as a data dictionary or codebook is included with the dataset submission.

Data Submission

Though what an individual should include in the "Submission Information Package" (SIP) to the ICPSR is not explicitly stated (SIP was not a term that I found the repository to use), the ICPSR does provide some guidance for what a potential data depositor should deliver. Other than the "Data Deposit Form" (which must be submitted), for my specific type of dataset, the dataset must be in SPSS, SAS, or Stata format, variable and value labels must be included, and a codebook or data dictionary that describes or defines the variables in the dataset must be provided. In addition, the ICPSR includes a "Depositor Checklist" which contains a more exhaustive list of what an individual could provide.

There are two ways that an individual can submit their data: self-publishing or through professional curation. With self-publishing, the potential data depositor is responsible for “cleaning and formatting [their] data, creating metadata, reviewing for disclosure risks, and providing documentation” (“Deposit Your Data”). For assistance with data submission, individuals are prompted to reach out via email with their questions and concerns. If an individual decides to instead go with professional curation, the ICPSR will provide user support as well as other benefits like converting data to SAS, SPSS and other formats, creating the metadata record, creating a standardized codebook, and providing a suggested data citation.

Metadata Specifics

The ICPSR allows users to view metadata formatted according to either the Data Documentation Initiative (DDI) or the Dublin Core standard. The repository’s core study-level metadata are based on the DDI framework, which emphasizes elements such as a consistent study title across files, a detailed project description, the full names and institutional affiliations of the Principal Investigator(s), data collection dates, the unit of analysis (who or what is being studied), descriptions of the sample and universe, a project website (if available), and information about funding sources and grant numbers.

Data Dissemination

Similar to the “Submission Information Package,” the contents of the “Dissemination Information Package” (DIP) are not explicitly defined. However, it was possible to infer what ICPSR typically includes in the DIP. This would appear to consist

of a study homepage containing information about dataset access and metadata, along with usage statistics and download counts displayed on the same page. Additionally, for datasets curated by ICPSR, data are also made available in multiple formats (such as R, SAS, SPSS, Stata, and delimited files) to support broader usability.

Additional Information

Recommended data citation (from Kaggle):

APA: BwandoWando, and ICE Team Members. (2025). 🇺🇸 ICE Arrests, Detentions, & Deportations Data [Data set]. Kaggle. <https://doi.org/10.34740/KAGGLE/DS/9016458>

Considerations for Long-Term Preservation:

These datasets are available in .xlsx, .csv, and .parquet formats, none of which are proprietary.

Files in the .xlsx and .csv formats can be opened using microsoft excel or google sheets. The .parquet files can be viewed by downloading ParquetViewer, using an online viewer like [ParquetReader.com](https://parquetreader.com), or by using programming applications like Python or R.

The copyright license that I believe would be most appropriate for this data set is the GNU General Public License v3.0.

Human Subject Considerations:

There is no personally identifiable data within the datasets. Though the datasets contain individual-level data, they have been anonymized by using a unique ID for each person's "alien file number" (or "A-number"). These A-numbers enable a user to track a person's enforcement path from arrest to detention to deportation within the datasets.

References

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